Arsalan Diamaoden

Dr. Arsalan A. Diamaoden is a Meranaw public servant, academician, researcher, and traditional leader from Butig in Lanao del Sur, Philippines. He currently serves as the **Chairperson of the Bangsamoro Sports Commission (BSC)**, the principal sports development body of the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). A man shaped as much by the lakes and highlands of Lanao as by the lecture halls of Mindanao State University, Diamaoden has built a career that weaves together scholarship, faith-grounded governance, and a genuine conviction that sports can be a doorway to lasting peace in the Bangsamoro.

He holds traditional titles that carry deep weight in the Meranaw world, including **Sultan A. Cabugatan of the Royal House of Poctan** and **Pat Ka Wata sa Mama of Dianaton Naim sa Butig**, a combination of hereditary standing and personal achievement that sets him apart in any room he enters. His trajectory from classroom dean to regional commissioner reflects a generation of young Bangsamoro leaders who choose service over comfort, and who understand that development means nothing if it does not reach the community.

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Early Life and Background

Arsalan A. Diamaoden grew up in Butig, a municipality nestled in the interior of Lanao del Sur that scholars and local historians sometimes call the "cradle of Meranaw civilization."<ref name="butig2022">Diamaoden, A. A. (2022). Butig, Lanao Del Sur, The Cradle of Meranaw Civilization: A Critical Analysis. *Psychology and Education: A Multidisciplinary Journal, 5*(10), 863–871. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.7364236</ref>

Butig is no ordinary hometown. It was among the earliest settlements where sharifs arriving from the Arabian Peninsula planted the seeds of Islam in the Lanao highlands, establishing the sultanate system that would define Meranaw political and social life for centuries. Growing up here meant inheriting a living tradition: a culture of

taritib (protocol) and *igma* (custom), a reverence for learning rooted in the Quranic tradition, and a community that measures a man not just by his title, but by his service to others.

This environment shaped Diamaoden early. He comes from the Diamaoden family of Butig, a family with documented roots in the Royal House of Poctan and a long history of community leadership in Lanao del Sur.<ref name="butig2022"/> His upbringing exposed him to the language of both traditional governance and grassroots need, and it gave him a framework he has carried into every role he has held since.

Education

Diamaoden pursued his higher education at Mindanao State University (MSU) in Marawi City, one of the country's premier public universities and a historic center of Muslim Filipino learning. He completed his undergraduate degree with a **Bachelor of Arts in Islamic Studies, Major in Shari'ah**, followed by a **Master of Arts in Islamic Studies**, both from MSU. These degrees grounded him in Islamic jurisprudence, Meranaw cultural history, and the intellectual traditions of Muslim Mindanao.

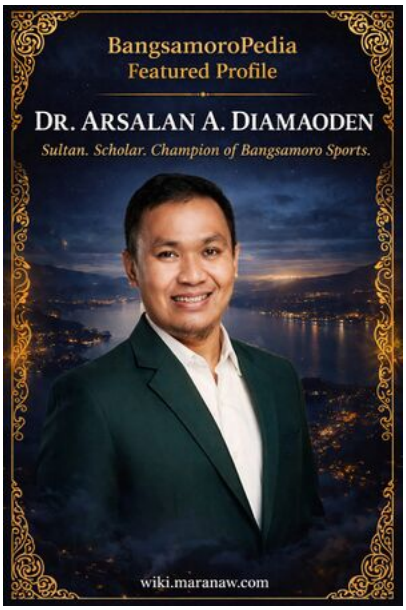
He then went on to earn a **Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) in Mindanao Culture and Society** from the College of Social Sciences and Humanities at MSU. His doctoral dissertation tackled one of the most consequential policy questions of his generation:

> *The Status, Challenges, and Prospects of the Implementation of Political and Socio-Economic Tracks of the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro: A Basis for Implementation Mechanism Intervention*

The dissertation was not an armchair exercise. It dug into the real, lived realities of the Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro (CAB) and the structural gaps between what the peace agreement promised and what communities were actually experiencing on the ground. It positioned Diamaoden early on as both a scholar of Bangsamoro affairs and a policy thinker with practical instincts.

He later enrolled in the executive course in **Leadership, Innovation, Communication, and Knowledge Management** (DAP-GSPDM) at the Development Academy of the Philippines (DAP), in a program offered in collaboration with Aboitiz Equity Ventures (AEV) and the National Union of Career Executive Service Officers (NUCESO). His foresight paper for this program, titled *Sports in Bangsamoro 2050: Advancement or Downfall*, would prove to be almost prophetic in laying out the strategic case for sports development in the region.

Arsalan A. Diamaoden



Born	Butig, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Religion	Islam
Traditional Titles	Sultan A. Cabugatan, Royal House of Poctan; Pat Ka Wata sa Mama of Dianaton Naim sa Butig
Education	Mindanao State University (B.A., M.A., Ph.D.); Philippine Christian University (Post-Doctoral)
Alma mater	Mindanao State University; Philippine Christian University; Development Academy of the Philippines
Known for	Chairperson, Bangsamoro Sports Commission; Outstanding Dean, International Education Summit 2020; 12-Point Agenda on Sports; Bangsamoro Sports Development Plan
Political party	Independent
Current position	Chairperson, Bangsamoro Sports Commission, BARMM

On November 29, 2024, he completed a **Post-Doctoral Degree in Strategic Leadership and Management** at Philippine Christian University, adding a second postgraduate research credential to an already exceptional academic record.<ref name="docx-source">Source document:

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Career

Academic Career

Before stepping into public administration, Diamaoden built a name for himself as an educator. He served as the **Dean of Al-Bangsamoro Shari'ah and Professional Education College** in Marawi City from 2017 to 2019, a period that coincided with the aftermath of the Marawi siege and one of the most difficult chapters of reconstruction in the city's modern history.<ref name="iesa2020">Bangsamoro Information Office. (March 2, 2020). Bangsamoro Young Educator receives International Education Awards. *Luwaran.com*. https://www.luwaran.com/news/article/2011/bangsamoro-young-educator-receives-international-education-awards-</ref>

His approach to academic leadership was anything but conventional. He pushed for innovative teaching methods that engaged students beyond rote learning, established student clubs designed to tap into different types of intelligence, and maintained a personal commitment to the communities around his institution. He volunteered in feeding programs organized by both government and non-government organizations, and he personally initiated a fundraising project to provide school supplies for orphaned students at a madrasa (Islamic school) in his hometown of Butig.<ref name="iesa2020"/>

As an academic, he has also contributed meaningfully to scholarship on Bangsamoro history and culture. Among his published works are a study on the decommissioning of Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF) combatants in Butig and its implications for peace,<ref name="ijmaber2021">Diamaoden, A. A., et al. (2021). The Decommissioning of the Moro Islamic Liberation Front Combatants in Camp Darul Arham, Butig Lanao Del Sur and Its Implication to Peace. *International Journal of Multidisciplinary: Applied Business and Education Research, 2*(3). https://doi.org/10.11594/ijmaber.02.03.07</ref> and his 2022 critical analysis on Butig as the historical cradle of Meranaw civilization.<ref name="butig2022"/> He has also produced research on Meranaw oral traditions, including the *Pananaroon* (Meranaw proverbs), Islamic perspectives on land ownership, and peace-building dynamics in Lanao del Sur.

Entry into Public Service: Bangsamoro Sports Commission

Diamaoden's transition from the college deanship to public service came through his appointment as **Commissioner for Lanao del Sur** at the Bangsamoro Sports Commission (BSC). The BSC was established as a key sports governance body of the BARMM, with a mandate to develop athletic programs, promote grassroots sports participation, preserve traditional and indigenous games, and support Bangsamoro athletes in regional and national competitions.<ref name="pna2022">Philippine News Agency. (March 29, 2022). PSC boosts ties with Bangsamoro Sports Commission. https://www.pna.gov.ph/articles/1170938</ref>

In June 2023, he was elevated to **Chairperson of the Bangsamoro Sports Commission**, taking the helm of the Commission and reorienting its strategic direction.<ref name="docx-source"/> He was subsequently **re-appointed as Chairperson in August 2025**, a clear vote of institutional confidence from the Bangsamoro Government.<ref name="docx-source"/>

Chairmanship of the Bangsamoro Sports Commission

The 12-Point Agenda on Sports

Among Diamaoden's first significant acts as Chairperson was presenting a **12-Point Agenda** to the Philippine Sports Commission (PSC), outlining BSC's framework for sports development in the Bangsamoro.<ref name="psc2023">Philippine Sports Commission. (November 29, 2023). Bangsamoro Sports Commission lays out 12-point agenda to PSC. https://psc.gov.ph/psc_site/bangsamoro-sports-commission-lays-out-12-point-agenda-to-psc/</ref>

The agenda covered: sports facilities development, health and wellness programs, grassroots and youth sports, sports education, human resource development, continuation of the Sports for All programs, elite sports identification, traditional and indigenous sports preservation, gender equity in sports, regional linkages and collaboration, sports tourism, and sports competition development. The scope of this agenda made it clear that his vision for BSC was not simply about winning medals. It was about using sports as an instrument of Bangsamoro identity, wellbeing, and peace.

Grassroots Programs and Athlete Incentivization

Under Diamaoden's leadership, the BSC expanded its reach into communities that had historically been underserved by organized sports. The commission conducted sports clinics in Marawi City, Basilan, Sulu, and Tawi-Tawi, with training sessions that covered not just athletic technique but also teamwork, sportsmanship, and mental preparation for young participants.<ref name="barmm-sports-clinic">BARMM Official Website. (July 4, 2024). Young athletes in Marawi undergo intensive sports clinic. Bangsamoro Information Office. https://bangsamoro.gov.ph/news/latest-news/young-athletes-in-marawi-undergo-intensive-sports-clinic/</ref>

The commission also institutionalized a **cash assistance program** for Bangsamoro athletes competing in national and international competitions, ensuring that financial constraints would not prevent talented young athletes from representing the region at the highest levels. In February 2025, for instance, the BSC provided cash grants to 24 Karatedo athletes from Mindanao State University-Marawi ahead of the 6th Karate Pilipinas National Championships, with four of those athletes returning home with medals.<ref name="barmm-karate">BARMM Official Website. (March 5, 2025). Mga atletang Bangsamoro tumanggap ng tulong pinansyal, nag-uwi ng medalya sa nat'l competition. Bangsamoro Information Office. https://bangsamoro.gov.ph/news/barmm-ngayon/mga-atletang-bangsamoro-tumanggap-ng-tulong-pinansyal/</ref>

The B-SMART ID and Talent Identification

One of the more innovative programs introduced during his tenure is the **B-SMART ID**, a talent identification system designed to discover and develop young sports prospects across the Bangsamoro region. The program reflects Diamaoden's belief that the region is full of athletic talent that simply hasn't had the right institutional support to emerge. Mapping potential rather than waiting for it to surface on its own has become a defining feature of how the BSC approaches youth development under his watch.<ref name="sobsa2025">Bangsamoro Sports Commission. (October 8, 2025). 1st State of the Bangsamoro Sports Address highlights milestones in sports promotion, development, and partnership building in BARMM. https://bsc.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2025/10/08/1st-state-of-the-bangsamoro-sports-address-highlights-milestones-in-sports-promotion-development-and-partnership-building-in-barmm/</ref>

Preserving Indigenous Sports

Diamaoden has consistently championed the integration of traditional Bangsamoro games into the BSC's program portfolio. Under his leadership, the Commission conducted Indigenous Peoples Games in South Upi, Maguindanao del Sur, as part of the celebration of Indigenous Peoples Month 2025, gathering children from indigenous communities to compete in traditional games that carry cultural memory as much as athletic value.<ref name="ipgames2025">Bangsamoro Sports Commission. (November 3, 2025). BSC caps off 2-day Indigenous Peoples Games in celebration of Indigenous Peoples Month 2025. https://bsc.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2025/11/03/</ref>

This isn't just nostalgia. Diamaoden understands that when indigenous games disappear, a community loses something it can't get back from a Wikipedia article. Bringing these games back into the public square, particularly for children, is a quiet but powerful act of cultural continuity.

The 1st State of the Bangsamoro Sports Address

On October 6, 2025, Chairperson Diamaoden delivered the historic **1st State of the Bangsamoro Sports Address (SOBSA)** at the Shariff Kabunsuan Cultural Complex in Cotabato City. The event brought together athletes, coaches, sports stakeholders, and Bangsamoro government officials in what became a milestone moment for sports governance in the region. In his address, Diamaoden presented the accomplishments of the BSC from 2021 to 2025 and outlined the road ahead. He articulated a vision that was as much about social transformation as athletic achievement:

> "This occasion was more than just a meeting of minds. It is a celebration of unity, resilience, and shared purpose among all who believe in the power of sports to transform lives and communities."

<ref name="pna-summit">Philippine News Agency. (November 9, 2025). Mindanao Sports Summit nurtures peace through sports. https://www.pna.gov.ph/articles/1262908</ref>

The address highlighted key institutional achievements, including the formulation of the **Bangsamoro Sports Development Plan**, the adoption of enabling policies for athlete and coach incentivization, the mapping of around 60 sports clubs and organizations across BARMM, and the development of key administrative frameworks including the Commission's Operations Manual and Strategic Performance Management System (SPMS).<ref name="sobsa2025"/>

Institutional Partnerships

Diamaoden has been active in building a network of partnerships for the BSC. He met with Philippine Sports Commission (PSC) Chairman Patrick Gregorio to jointly plan the **Mindanao Sports Summit** held at Mindanao State University in Marawi City on November 6–7, 2025, focused on grassroots sports development and talent identification across Mindanao.<ref name="sunstar-psc">SunStar Davao. (October 22, 2025). PSC, BSC boost BARMM sports. https://www.sunstar.com.ph/davao/sports/psc-bsc-boost-barmm-sports</ref>

He also led the BSC delegation in a partnership meeting with **Otsuka-Solar Philippines** (manufacturer of Pocari Sweat) in January 2026, culminating in the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) covering athlete hydration and wellness initiatives, as well as coordinated sports promotion across BARMM.<ref name="bsc-otsuka">Bangsamoro Sports Commission. (January 28, 2026). BSC, Otsuka-Solar Philippines seal partnership for sports promotion and development in BARMM. https://bsc.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2026/01/28/bsc-otsuka-solar-philippines-seal-partnership-for-sports-promotion-and-development-in-barmm/</ref>

In January 2026, he also received a courtesy visit from **MILO Philippines** at the BSC office in Cotabato City, opening discussions on further collaboration to expand sports programs for Bangsamoro youth.<ref name="bsc-milo">Bangsamoro Sports Commission. (January 28, 2026). MILO Philippines pays courtesy visit to Bangsamoro Sports Commission. https://bsc.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2026/01/28/</ref>

Bangsamoro athletes, meanwhile, have been making their presence felt nationally and regionally. BARMM representatives earned one gold, three silver, and four bronze medals at the 11th BIMP-EAGA (Brunei Darussalam, Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines-East ASEAN Growth Area) Friendship Games in Puerto Princesa City, a performance that Diamaoden cited as proof that investment in Bangsamoro sports is paying off.<ref name="sunstar-psc"/>

Traditional Leadership

Alongside his public service career, Diamaoden carries the hereditary distinction of **Sultan A. Cabugatan of the Royal House of Poctan** and **Pat Ka Wata sa Mama of Dianaton Naim sa Butig**. These are not merely ceremonial titles in the Meranaw world. The sultanate system remains a living institution in Lanao, with sultans playing an active role in community mediation, social cohesion, and the preservation of *taritib* and *igma*, the twin pillars of Meranaw customary law and protocol.<ref name="docx-source"/>

For Diamaoden, holding these titles means carrying a dual responsibility: to the people who elected him to public office, and to the community that has entrusted him with ancestral authority. He has spoken about bridging the gap between traditional sultanate leadership and the demands of modern democratic governance, and his career can be read as a sustained effort to do exactly that.

Recognition and Awards

- **Outstanding Dean**, International Education Summit and Awards (IESA) 2020, held at Divalux Resort, Bangkok, Thailand (February 22, 2020). The IESA recognized Diamaoden among more than 250 distinguished educators from across Asia for his contributions to innovative academic leadership during his tenure at Al-Bangsamoro Shari'ah and Professional Education College.<ref name="iesa2020"/>
- **Asia's Most Exceptional Leadership/Educator and Humanitarian Advocate of the Year** (year of award to be confirmed).<ref name="docx-source"/>
- His **100 Days of Leadership** at the BSC were noted as marking a new phase in the Commission's institutional development.<ref name="docx-source"/>

Personal Values and Cultural Significance

Diamaoden has often spoken about the Meranaw concept of ***kambilangataw***, meaning a role model in character and good deeds, as the standard he holds himself to. This is not a management slogan for him. It's a code. It shows up in his decision to volunteer at feeding programs when he was still a dean, in his commitment to bring sports clinics to marginalized communities in Lanao del Sur, and in the way he speaks about athletes, not as statistics, but as young people whose futures depend on whether the state shows up for them.<ref name="docx-source"/>

His Ramadan messages as BSC Chairperson have offered a window into how he integrates his Islamic faith with his governance philosophy. He has written that Ramadan is a reminder that "true fulfillment comes not from material wealth, but from humility, generosity, and a heart full of sincerity," framing the month not just as a

religious observance but as a call to public service.<ref name="bsc-ramadan">Bangsamoro Sports Commission. (March 3, 2025). Message of Bangsamoro Sports Commission Chairperson Dr. Arsalan Diamaoden on the observance of the Holy Month of Ramadan 1446 AH. https://bsc.bangsamoro.gov.ph/2025/03/03/</ref>

He approaches governance through three overlapping lenses: moral accountability rooted in Islamic ethics, traditional Meranaw values of communal responsibility, and a contemporary, evidence-based approach to policy and institutional design. The combination is relatively rare in Philippine public life, and it's what makes him a figure of genuine cultural significance in the Bangsamoro.

Legacy

It may be early in his career to speak of legacy in the past tense, but the shape of what Diamaoden is building is already clear. He is constructing a sports governance system in the Bangsamoro that works not just for elite athletes, but for the child in the barrio who has never seen a proper court. He is using sports as a language of peace in a region that knows too well what the absence of peace looks like. And he is doing it while carrying the weight of ancestral tradition in one hand and the framework of modern governance in the other.

His foresight paper at the Development Academy of the Philippines asked a blunt question: "Sports in Bangsamoro 2050: Advancement or Downfall?" The work he is doing now is his answer. He is betting, institution by institution and program by program, that the answer is advancement, and that the Bangsamoro's best athletic years are still ahead.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Sports Commission
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Mindanao State University
- Butig, Lanao del Sur
- Meranaw people
- Comprehensive Agreement on the Bangsamoro
- Philippine Sports Commission
- Bangsamoro Transition Authority

Further Reading

- Diamaoden, A. A. (2022). Butig, Lanao Del Sur, The Cradle of Meranaw Civilization: A Critical Analysis. *Psychology and Education: A Multidisciplinary Journal, 5*(10), 863–871.
- Diamaoden, A. A., et al. (2021). The Decommissioning of the Moro Islamic Liberation Front Combatants in Camp Darul Arham, Butig Lanao Del Sur and Its Implication to Peace. *International Journal of Multidisciplinary: Applied Business and Education Research, 2*(3).
- Bangsamoro Sports Commission. (2025). 1st State of the Bangsamoro Sports Address (SOBSA). Cotabato City: BSC.
- Diamaoden, A. A. (2024). Sports in Bangsamoro 2050: Advancement or Downfall (Foresight Paper). Development Academy of the Philippines.
- Bangsamoro Sports Commission. Official Website. https://bsc.bangsamoro.gov.ph

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